Joseph R. Etherage PsyD, ABPP

Board-certified clinical psychologist who has spent three decades building and overseeing behavioral-health systems, from military screening and suicide surveillance to national healthcare inspection, and who now builds and evaluates AI tools for evidence-based review.

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I'm Joe Etherage. My work has three threads. As a clinician, I led behavioral-health departments and programs for the U.S. Air Force, the U.S. Army and NATO's Supreme Headquarters Allied Powers Europe. As a builder, I designed and ran measurement systems: post-deployment screening that assessed 41,000 soldiers, and a suicide-event report that the Department of Defense adopted department-wide. As an overseer, I have directed healthcare inspection work that tests whether systems do what they claim, most recently on generative AI in clinical care.

In 2026 I founded JE Vectors LLC and built Inqura, an evidence-analysis platform for investigations and compliance review, along with ConKurrence, a harness for measuring whether AI judgments hold up. I am interested in AI oversight, healthcare and mental-health AI governance, and evaluation, as an employee or as a consultant.

EXPERIENCE

Founder
2026 – present

JE Vectors LLC, Florida

- Designed and shipped Inqura, an evidence-analysis platform for investigations and compliance review, and ConKurrence, a multi-model evaluation harness. Both are described under Systems built.

Director, Strategy and Innovation
Apr 2024 – Oct 2026

Office of Healthcare Inspections, U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs Office of Inspector General. Retired from federal service October 2026.

- Director of the team that produced the Office of Inspector General's two national reviews of generative AI in the Veterans Health Administration (January and June 2026), listed under Publications.

Director, National Reporting
Jun 2021 – Apr 2024

Office of Healthcare Inspections, U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs Office of Inspector General

- Directed national healthcare inspection reporting, including six reports on patient harm, medication management, care coordination, metrics, ticketing and training after a new electronic health record went live (2021–2022).
- Briefed review findings to senior leaders in the Office of Inspector General and the Veterans Health Administration, and to members of Congress and their staff.

Director, Hotline 10 (healthcare inspections)
Apr 2019 – Jun 2021

Office of Healthcare Inspections, U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs Office of Inspector General

- Directed a portfolio of healthcare inspections that addressed hotline allegations, deciding which complaints warranted inspection and how the evidence would be tested, and publishing findings and recommendations for facilities and the Veterans Health Administration.

Chief, Yukon Embedded Behavioral Health Clinic
Apr 2018 – Apr 2019

Department of Behavioral Health, Madigan Army Medical Center, Joint Base Lewis-McChord, WA

Clinical Research Psychologist

Aug 2016 – Apr 2018

Department of Behavioral Health, Madigan Army Medical Center, Joint Base Lewis-McChord, WA

Chief, Department of Behavioral Health, and Installation Director of Psychological Health

Aug 2013 – Aug 2016

Supreme Headquarters Allied Powers Europe (SHAPE), Belgium

- Led behavioral health, family advocacy and developmental intervention services for NATO and Partnership for Peace staff and their families from 50 countries, including the response after the March 2016 Brussels bombings.
- Advised SHAPE leaders on psychological health policy, and served as contracting officer's representative for psychiatric services.

Chief, Programs and Research Service

Sep 2010 – Aug 2013

Department of Behavioral Health, Madigan Army Medical Center, Joint Base Lewis-McChord, WA

- Led a team of research and clinical psychologists that designed and ran the behavioral-health programs at Joint Base Lewis-McChord, and oversaw program evaluation and research for the department.
- Co-authored D-RAT, a screening instrument the Army adopted for all redeploying soldiers (ALARACT 237-2010).
- Served as the command's behavioral-health subject-matter expert, briefing general officers, senior Army Medical Command officials and members of Congress.

Deputy Chief, Department of Psychology

Aug 2005 – Aug 2010

Madigan Army Medical Center, Joint Base Lewis-McChord, WA

- Deputy chief of the largest Department of Psychology in the Department of Defense (behavioral medicine, behavioral health and soldier readiness services at four locations); rater for more than 90 staff, including over 50 clinicians, and acting chief in the chief's absence.
- Created a population-health, stepped-care model that gave service members and families at Joint Base Lewis-McChord same-day access to evidence-based behavioral healthcare.
- Program lead for SELF post-deployment screening; contributed to the Army Suicide Event Report and the Automated Behavioral Health Clinic (see Systems built). Led a telehealth screening of a combat brigade returning to Alaska.
- Helped stand up the National Center for Telehealth and Technology: initial organizational structure, funding and first personnel actions.

Director, Clinical Psychology Residency Program

Mar 2005 – Jul 2005

Malcolm Grow Medical Center, Andrews Air Force Base, MD

Chief, Behavioral Medicine Service

Jun 2004 – Jul 2005

Malcolm Grow Medical Center, Andrews Air Force Base, MD

- Led pediatric and adult health psychology services, including primary-care behavioral health consultation to five clinics.
- Selected as the Air Force psychology consultant for AHLTA, the Department of Defense electronic health record. Upgraded and distributed ANSOR, an Access database used by Air Force mental health clinics for clinical documentation and caseload management.
- Team leader for behavioral-health consultation to the Presidential Airlift Group and the 1st and 99th Airlift Squadrons, including a suicide-prevention briefing to the Presidential Airlift Group in the Air Force One hangar.

Pediatric Psychologist, Behavioral Medicine Services

Aug 2000 – May 2004

Malcolm Grow Medical Center, Andrews Air Force Base, MD

- Primary consultant to the Security Forces Squadron's hostage negotiation team (2000–2005), after FBI crisis negotiation training.

Chief, Psychological Services

Aug 1997 – Aug 1999

30th Medical Group Mental Health Clinic, Vandenberg Air Force Base, CA

SYSTEMS BUILT

Inqura

2026 · JE Vectors LLC

An evidence-analysis platform for investigations and compliance review, designed and built solo with Claude Code as the engineering agent. Every claim in a finding cites its evidence, every finding carries a confidence level, and the server blocks sign-off until the reviewer has opened the cited evidence.

I wrote the original ten-criteria evidence-evaluation framework, then validated it down to the one-page guide that runs in production: two judgments per piece of evidence (is it relevant; does it have a material limitation), with an explicit materiality threshold. In controlled multi-model tests, rater agreement rose from chance level to substantial. I validate its accuracy claims through repeated independent tests and revise them as the results come in.

ConKurrence

2026 · JE Vectors LLC

A multi-model evaluation harness (command line, MCP server and web interface; 194+ automated tests) that measures whether AI judgments agree with each other and with expert anchors, so accuracy claims can be tested rather than asserted.

SELF: Soldier Evaluation for Life Fitness

2008 – 2009 · Madigan Army Medical Center

Program lead for post-deployment behavioral-health screening at Madigan and Fort Lewis: 41,000 assessments and 16,000 referrals, extended to Schofield Barracks, Hawaii, in 2009.

ASER → DoDSER

2005 – 2008 · U.S. Army

Helped develop the Army Suicide Event Report, the Army's suicide surveillance record. The Department of Defense built its department-wide DoD Suicide Event Report from it, launched January 2008.

Automated Behavioral Health Clinic

2005 – 2008 · U.S. Army

Clinical champion and product owner of the Army web application the SELF program ran on. Presented as a model for the military electronic health record's behavioral-health module (2008).

D-RAT: Down-Range Assessment Tool

2010 · U.S. Army

Co-author of a leader-completed screening instrument, with manual, that the Army adopted for all redeploying soldiers (ALARACT 237-2010).

PUBLICATIONS

PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES AND BOOK CHAPTERS

2012 · Jones, M. D., **Etherage, J. R.**, Harmon, S. C., & Okiishi, J. C. Acceptability and cost-effectiveness of military telehealth mental health screening. *Psychological Services, 9*(2), 132–143. doi:10.1037/a0026709

2012 · Harmon, S. C., Hoyt, T. V., Jones, M. D., **Etherage, J. R.**, & Okiishi, J. C. Postdeployment mental health screening: An application of the Soldier Adaptation Model. *Military Medicine, 177*(4), 366–373. doi:10.7205/MILMED-D-11-00343

2010 · Shearer, D. S., & **Etherage, J. R.** The practice of medical psychology in a military primary care medicine setting. *Journal of the Academy of Medical Psychology, 1*(1), 14–18.

2008 · Reger, M. A., **Etherage, J. R.**, Reger, G. M., & Gahm, G. A. Civilian psychologists in an Army culture: The ethical challenge of cultural competence. *Military Psychology, 20*(1), 21–35. doi:10.1080/08995600701753144

2005 · **Etherage, J.** Pediatric behavioral health consultation: A new model for primary care. In L. James & R. Folen (Eds.), *The Primary Care Consultant: The Next Frontier for Psychologists in Hospitals and Clinics*. Washington, DC: American Psychological Association. doi:10.1037/10962-009

2003 · Dobmeyer, A. C., Rowan, A. B., **Etherage, J. R.**, & Wilson, R. J. Training psychology interns in primary behavioral health care. *Professional Psychology: Research and Practice, 34*(6), 586–594. doi:10.1037/0735-7028.34.6.586

2000 · Scharff, L., & **Etherage, J.** The role of minimal and no-contact behavioral treatments in migraine: A review of efficacy and cost effectiveness. *Disease Management and Health Outcomes, 8*(6), 313–325. doi:10.2165/00115677-200008060-00002

OVERSIGHT REPORTS

Reports of the U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs Office of Inspector General, Office of Healthcare Inspections. These are institutional publications; I contributed to each as a director in that office.

June 11, 2026 · *Review of Generative Artificial Intelligence Chat Tools for Clinical Use* (Report 26-00182-140)

January 15, 2026 · *Review of VHA's Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence* (Report 26-00182-42)

October 31, 2023 · *Improvements Needed in Lung Cancer Screening Through Use of Community Care*

August 16, 2023 · *Concern with Veterans Health Administration's Lung Cancer Screening Program Requirements*

July 14, 2022 · *The New Electronic Health Record's Unknown Queue Caused Multiple Events of Patient Harm*

July 7, 2022 · *OIG Determination of Veterans Health Administration's Occupational Staffing Shortages, Fiscal Year 2022*

June 1, 2022 · *Deficits with Metrics Following Implementation of the New Electronic Health Record at the Mann-Grandstaff VA Medical Center in Spokane, Washington*

May 3, 2022 · *Facility Leaders' Response to Inappropriate Mental Health Provider-Patient Relationships at the VA Illiana Health Care System in Danville, Illinois*

March 17, 2022 · *Medication Management Deficiencies after the New Electronic Health Record Go-Live at the Mann-Grandstaff VA Medical Center in Spokane, Washington*

March 17, 2022 · *Ticket Process Concerns and Underlying Factors Contributing to Deficiencies after the New Electronic Health Record Go-Live at the Mann-Grandstaff VA Medical Center in Spokane, Washington*

March 17, 2022 · *Care Coordination Deficiencies after the New Electronic Health Record Go-Live at the Mann-Grandstaff VA Medical Center in Spokane, Washington*

August 24, 2021 · *Deficiencies in Coordination of Care for Patients with Treatment-Resistant Depression at the VA San Diego Healthcare System in California*

July 8, 2021 · *Training Deficiencies with VA's New Electronic Health Record System at the Mann-Grandstaff VA Medical Center in Spokane, Washington*

August 27, 2020 · *Alleged Deficiencies in the Management of Staff Exposure to a Patient with COVID-19 at the VA Portland Health Care System in Oregon*

April 27, 2020 · *Inadequate Care by a Clinical Pharmacy Specialist and a Primary Care Provider at the Tennessee Valley Healthcare System in Nashville*

INSTRUMENTS

2010 · **Etherage, J.**, Harmon, S. C., Jones, M. D., & Slade, K. *D-RAT: The Down-Range Assessment Tool* (assessment instrument and manual). Adopted Army-wide by All Army Activities message ALARACT 237-2010.

PROFESSIONAL ARTICLES

2002 · **Etherage, J.** Pediatric primary care psychology. *The Air Force Psychologist*, *20*(3), 6–7.

2000 · **Etherage, J.** Camelot revisited: The pediatric psychology fellowship. *The Air Force Psychologist*, *18*(4), 7–8.

PRESENTATIONS AND POSTERS

2011 · Okiishi, J. C., **Etherage, J. R.**, Harmon, S. C., & Jones, M. D. *Soldiers at risk: Early identification of soldiers at need through multimodal assessment.* Poster, Annual Meeting of the American Psychological Association, Washington, DC.

2010 · Harmon, S. C., Slade, K., Jones, M. D., & **Etherage, J.** *Soldier Evaluation for Life Fitness (SELF): A response to the mental health needs of post-deployment soldiers.* Annual Meeting of the Society for Psychotherapy Research, Monterey, CA.

2008 · Brown, M., & **Etherage, J.** *Building a new AHLTA behavioral health module: Utilizing the Automated Behavioral Health Clinic as a model.* 11th Annual Force Health Protection Conference, Albuquerque, NM.

1996 · **Etherage, J.**, Deatherage, R., Cornelius, K., & Moiso, K. *The development of a nonlingual format for measuring emotional expression.* Poster, Annual Meeting of the Hawaii Psychological Association, Honolulu, HI.

1991 · Pitts, M., Barnett, O., & **Etherage, J.** *The inadequacy of social support for battered women.* Poster, Annual Meeting of the Western Psychological Association, CA.

EDUCATION AND CREDENTIALS

PsyD, Clinical Psychology, Pepperdine University, Graduate School of Education and Psychology · 1997

MS, Clinical Psychopharmacology, Fairleigh Dickinson University · 2016

MA, Psychology, Pepperdine University, Graduate School of Education and Psychology · 1993

BA, Psychology, Seaver College, Pepperdine University · 1991

Fellowship in Pediatric Behavioral Medicine, Harvard Medical School (Massachusetts General Hospital and Children's Hospital Boston) · 1999 – 2000

Internship in Clinical Psychology (APA-accredited), Wilford Hall Medical Center, Lackland Air Force Base, TX · 1996 – 1997

CERTIFICATION AND LICENSURE

Board Certified in Clinical Psychology, American Board of Professional Psychology · 2004 – present

Licensed Psychologist, Florida (PY12078)

Professional Scrum Master, Scrum.org · 2021

RECENT PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

AI in Health Care: From Strategies to Implementation, Harvard Medical School, eight-week online executive education program · Feb – Apr 2026 · verify certificate

IAPP Artificial Intelligence Governance Professional (AIGP) · in preparation

SELECTED TRAINING

Investigation and crisis response: FBI Crisis Negotiations Training Course, FBI Critical Incident Response Group · 1998 · TapRooT root-cause analysis · 2012 · Aircraft Mishap Investigation and Prevention, USAF School of Aerospace Medicine · 2005 · Critical Incident Stress Management, ICISF · 2002 · Traumatic Event Management, Army Medical Department Center and School · 2018

Executive and management: Advanced Course, Army Management Staff College · 2017 · MedXcellence Medical Executive Skills, Uniformed Services University · 2015 · Contracting Officer's Representative, Army Logistics Management College · 2008 · Hospital Executive Leadership Program, Madigan Army Medical Center · 2006

Clinical: Suicide prevention with Thomas Joiner · 2017 · Cognitive Processing Therapy for PTSD, Center for Deployment Psychology · 2013 · Prolonged Exposure Therapy with Edna Foa · 2007 · Assessment and treatment of suicidal risk with David Jobes · 2006 · MMPI-2-RF with Yossef Ben-Porath · 2009 · Integrated primary mental health care with Kirk Strosahl · 2000

SERVICE AND AWARDS

U.S. Air Force Officer, psychologist

Jul 1996 – Aug 2005

Commissioned as a Captain; honorably discharged from active duty as a Major.

Meritorious Service Medal (one oak leaf cluster) · Commendation Medal · Achievement Medal · Global War on Terrorism Service Medal · Outstanding Unit Award (three oak leaf clusters)

AWARDS AND RECOGNITION

Inspector General's Exceptional Teamwork Award, VA Office of Inspector General · 2020, 2026

Outstanding Initiative Award, VA Office of Inspector General · 2023

Inspector General's Distinguished Achievement Award, VA Office of Inspector General · 2022

New Employee of the Year, Office of Healthcare Inspections · 2020

Commander's Award for Civilian Service · 2016

Commander's Coin for service following the Brussels bombings, SHAPE Healthcare Facility · 2016

Army Achievement Medal for Civilian Service · 2008, 2018

Quality Step Increase for annual performance · 2006

U.S. Air Force Senior Psychologist of the Year; Air Mobility Command Senior Psychologist of the Year · 2004

Letters and certificates of appreciation from Major General Horoho (2009), Brigadier General Baxter (2007), Lieutenant General Dubik (2006), Brigadier General Germann (2004) and Major General Timboe, for Operation Solace (2002)

I retired from federal service with the U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs on October 31, 2026. Nothing here is endorsed by the Department of Veterans Affairs or its Office of Inspector General.

Updated November 2026 · joe.etherage@gmail.com · josephetherage.com